

IRONROOT

No Zodiac / No Animals / Event-Driven Narrative Revision

Revision target: keep the grief, the Shadow, the Spirit Realm, oppressive ledgers, ash-cost magic, physical weapons, and dark handcrafted aesthetic. Remove zodiac, animal symbolism, animal enemies, animal save shrines, and one-note boss fights. Replace them with human, architectural, fungal, textile, iron, ash, glass, salt, root, and ledger imagery.

Core thesis: Ironroot is not a boss-rush. It is a city that remembers how the player touched it. Every major confrontation is a world event with several angles of attack, and every event mutates future routes, factions, witnesses, endings, and the Shadow.

1. New Aesthetic Rule

The new visual language is material, not mythic. No zodiac signs. No animal forms. No horned helmets. No animal skull shrines. No corrupted wolves, birds, beasts, or animal-coded ascensions. The fantasy texture comes from handmade violence: pitted iron, cracked ceramic, black wax, wet cloth, old roots, ledger stone, fungus geometry, ash in wounds, dull candlelight, and architecture being consumed from inside.

This keeps the locked tone: dark fantasy, not high fantasy; physical magic with ash residue, bruising, nosebleeds, cracked nails; weapons with names as oaths; oppressive institutions; gothic stone overtaken by organic mass. The art handoff already anchors the production look as pixel art, hi-bit, dark fantasy, side-scroller, handcrafted, nearest-neighbor, no anti-aliasing, limited-palette, black-background character reference, and atmospheric environment reference.

Remove	Replace With	Reason
Zodiac signs	Oath Disciplines	Player identity comes from chosen method, not astrology.
Animal skull shrines	Candle cairns, cracked bowls, nail-rings, cloth knots	Save points stay warm and intimate without animal remains.
Beast / ram ascension	Ash-bound human silhouette; armor splitting into vow-sutures	Transformation remains violent but human.
Corrupted wildlife	Rooted deserters, fungal oath-effigies, ash-warped debtors	Enemies remain tragic people, architecture, or matter gone wrong.
Boss arena	World Event site	A confrontation that can resolve by combat, faction leverage, Spirit route, sabotage, or Shadow collision.
Constellations	Scars, stitch-lines, ledgers, burn maps, nail constellations without stars	Pattern language becomes local and material.

2. Protagonist Revision

The protagonist remains the Vowless Knife: a retired Root-Pruner who once removed people, histories, and debts that the city decided could not continue. They found peace not through innocence, but through refusal. They buried the kukri named Kept Quiet, married, and kept a grave-orchard lit with a small hand-built lantern made by their spouse. That lantern is the last peaceful object in their life.

The inciting wound is now fully no-animal: death-tithe officials arrive to collect a burial debt, extinguish the grave-lantern, uproot the spouse-row, and chisel the spouse-name out of the grave marker. This is not a monster attack. It is paperwork enforced by knives. The protagonist cannot just grieve because in Ironroot an erased name does not remain dead - it becomes administratively unhappened.

Player identity no longer comes from zodiac class. It comes from an Oath Discipline: the method by which the protagonist learned to survive, kill, move, remember, or refuse. Backstory remains adaptive, but the identity axis is grounded in craft and wound rather than cosmic signs.

Discipline	Combat Grammar	Traversal Grammar	Ending Bias
Edge	Precise punish, parry routes, execution windows	Cut sealed cloth, split toll chains, sever root locks	Ends favor clean violence or mercy by restraint.
Weight	Hyper-armor, stagger control, grounded throws	Break stone vows, force jammed gates, hold collapsing rooms	Ends favor institution-breaking and public revolt.
Breath	Cast speed, feints, silence windows, recovery manipulation	Move through whisper vents, steal testimony, interrupt rituals	Ends favor truth, exposure, and witness networks.
Thread	Range traps, tether counters, repositioning	Stitch platforms, bind mechanisms, cross gaps	Ends favor bargaining, capture, and non-lethal resolution.
Ash	DoT, area denial, corpse-route pressure	Burn seals, reveal hidden ink, mark paths through smoke	Ends favor purges, ruins, and irreversible cleansing.
Root	Sustain, grapples, anchor states, terrain pull	Grow ladders, pin moving architecture, reopen buried passages	Ends favor survival, reclamation, and city healing.
Glass	High-risk crits, reflection counters, clone tells	Reflect beams, read hidden rooms, reveal Shadow scars	Ends favor self-knowledge and dangerous revelation.
Salt	Anti-magic, decay resistance, wound sealing	Preserve corpses, stop rot gates, stabilize Spirit breaches	Ends favor preservation, closure, and denial of corruption.

3. Bosses Become Events

A boss is a person with a health bar. An Ironroot Event is a place, a faction pressure, a moral wound, a route puzzle, a Shadow opportunity, and a combat problem all occupying the same room. The player may still fight a central figure, but that fight is only one face of the event.

Every major event reads accumulated state before it begins. It checks who was spared, which ledgers were stolen, which routes were learned through death, which factions were humiliated, which environmental objects were broken, and how the Shadow has adapted. The event then changes its layout, allies, witnesses, hazards, and possible resolutions.

Input	What It Tracks
Mercy Ledger	Counts spared debtors, freed prisoners, surrendered enemies, and accepted apologies.
Debt Heat	Rises when the player breaks toll systems, steals ledgers, avoids payment, or kills officials.
Shadow Scar Map	Stores repeated attacks, dodges, parries, spell aspects, deaths, and humiliations.
Faction Leverage	Which factions owe, fear, expose, shelter, or hunt the protagonist.
Spirit Route Knowledge	Hidden paths learned by dying in specific rooms or carrying corpse-route memory forward.
Environmental Damage	Burned gates, broken bridges, flooded corridors, missing bells, opened cages, cut chains.
Name Fragments	Pieces of the spouse-name recovered from ledgers, witnesses, grave-stone, and Spirit echoes.

Event Resolution Angles

- Combat angle: defeat the event champion, guards, or Shadow-influenced central figure.
- Faction angle: spend leverage, call witnesses, turn prisoners, blackmail officials, or redirect blame.
- Environment angle: flood, burn, collapse, cut, seal, ring, drain, starve, or overfeed the site.
- Spirit angle: die in the right place, return through the mirror, and change the living room from the dead side.
- Shadow angle: reject it, bargain with it, weaponize it, or let it testify against you.
- Mercy angle: leave a living witness who can later complicate or save you.

4. Metroidvania Geometry

The map remains an annular labyrinth: an outer public ring, a middle institutional ring, an inner root-memory ring, and a center that contains the Deep Ledger. The player repeatedly moves outward for leverage and returns inward with new ways to read old spaces. No minimap dependency. Landmarks, scratches, cloth colors, toll symbols, breath sounds, candle states, ash trails, and Spirit distortions carry navigation information.

Gates are no longer zodiac gates. They are discipline gates, event-state gates, Spirit-death gates, faction gates, and perception gates. The player is not blocked because they lack the correct sign. They are blocked because they have not learned the correct method or created the right world state.

5. Zone / Event Map

#	Zone / Event	Core Struggle	Angles	Consequence
1	The Quiet Grave-Orchard	Personal wound: the last grave-lantern is taken and the spouse-name is chiseled out.	Fight collectors; follow the mason; die under the grave arch; hide and hear the real order; let the Shadow mark the stone.	Opens the revenge route. Determines whether Act 1 begins as pursuit, investigation, or massacre.
2	Tollroad of Bent Knees	Movement as humiliation: pilgrims crawl through mud to pay ancestral debt.	Break toll chains; expose false receipts; smuggle debtors; burn the toll-house; challenge the Bridge-Saint publicly.	Changes road access, prices, patrol density, and which debtors later testify.
3	Cinder Parish	Faith as accounting: ash, bruises, cracked nails, confession taxes.	Steal confession rolls; interrupt mass; duel parish guards; flood the censorium with smoke; enter Spirit choir loft.	Determines whether the Church becomes afraid, angry, or politically exposed.
4	The Desperate Camp	The bandit camp is an armory pretending to be a village.	Kill the warlord; arm prisoners; reveal altar under the boss tent; sabotage stockpiles; bargain with hungry fighters.	Camp becomes ally, ruin, ambush zone, or Shadow farm depending on treatment.
5	Spirit Forest Mirror	Same geometry as the first forest, but emptied of warmth and certainty.	Corpse-run sprint; read reversed scratches; reach locked living rooms; carry a message from the dead; refuse the Shadow echo.	Unlocks death-gated routes and teaches the player that dying in the right place is traversal.
6	Glass Lung Aviary	Not birds: suspended glass respirators, wind organs, testimony cages, breath-taxes.	Silence vents; free witnesses; weaponize pressure; duel the choir captain; die inside the lung to reach the back chamber.	Controls whether truth spreads as rumor, evidence, or weaponized panic.
7	Widow Canal	Inheritance courts, drowned houses, floating veils, submerged bells.	Drain canal; sink records; rescue clerks; bind a marriage contract; let flood reach the lower parish.	Determines who owns the spouse-name and which endings remain legal.
8	Anvil Ward	Weapon names are oaths. Smiths remember every hand that held them.	Reforge Kept Quiet; spare the Patient Hammer; break oath-weapons; trade memories for steel; duel in the cooling troughs.	Changes weapon evolution and whether violence becomes craft, addiction, or testimony.
9	Index Ossuary	Archive of bone shelves and nameless ledgers. Memory is administered here.	Steal the index; restore erased names; erase your old crimes; let monks audit the Shadow; enter the dead stacks.	Determines whether the city remembers truth, myth, or the protagonist's old sins.
10	Court of Equal Knives	A trial that adapts to what the player has actually done.	Argue evidence; fight champions; call spared enemies as witnesses; assassinate the magistrate; let the Shadow testify.	Transforms the midgame from revenge into judgment of the player.
11	Molt Cathedral	Stone is being eaten by memory made flesh. The building sheds itself.	Collapse supports; lead refugees out; empower or starve the root; force faction confrontation; die beneath the altar.	Determines whether the city can be saved, must be amputated, or wants to become the Shadow.
12	Deep Ledger	Living archive: names beat inside the walls like trapped hearts.	Recover spouse-name; rewrite debts; release all names; bind the Ironroot; merge with Shadow; refuse all claims.	Locks most endings based on prior event state, not a final dialogue menu.
13	The Uncounted Margin	A place outside the map language. No gate, no icon, no declared quest.	Requires non-obvious restraint, route memory, unclaimed faction status, and a contradiction in the ledgers.	Rare 0.5% ending path. The player leaves not by winning, but by becoming unrecordable.

6. Act 1 Event Deep Dive: The Desperate Camp

The old bandit boss becomes The Camp Decides. The camp is not a monster nest. It is an armory pretending to be a village: hungry fighters, stolen goods, broken tents, prisoner cages, hidden altar, and a faint magenta wrongness nobody wants to name. The central warlord is still dangerous and human, but the event asks what the camp becomes after the player touches it.

Angle	Player Approach	Result
Straight Combat	Challenge the warlord in the cleared camp center.	Camp breaks into hostile survivors. Shadow gains clean combat data.
Prisoner Leverage	Free prisoners before confrontation and arm them from stolen racks.	The fight becomes a revolt. Some prisoners later testify or betray.
Altar Exposure	Find the altar under the boss tent before triggering the event.	The warlord may surrender, panic, or become a vessel depending on faction heat.
Stockpile Sabotage	Cut supports, oil stores, bell ropes, and ration crates.	Environment resolves phases of the event without needing a full duel.
Spirit Route	Die at the old altar, return behind the living tent wall.	Unlocks a reverse entrance and reveals who paid the camp.
Shadow Interference	Enter after repeated deaths or high aggression patterns.	The Shadow appears early and the event becomes a three-sided struggle.

7. Faction Roster - Geometry and Event Function

Faction	Principle	Real Function	Event Role
Ledger Church	Cause and Effect	Turns grief, burial, confession, and debt into legal metaphysics.	Can be exposed, burned, infiltrated, or forced to confess.
Toll-Saints	Rhythm	Make repetition sacred: pay, kneel, pass, return, pay again.	Road control faction; early-game pressure and late-game public revolt trigger.
Root-Pruners	Polarity	Old execution order that cut impossible histories out of the city.	The protagonist was one. They want the old knife back.
Index Monks	Mentalism	Decide which memories are administratively real.	Can restore, censor, or weaponize the spouse-name.
Anvil Covenant	Vibration	Forge oath-weapons that remember impacts, hands, and murders.	Upgrade faction. Can make violence honest or addictive.
Widow Courts	Gender / Union	Control marriage, inheritance, lineage, and posthumous ownership.	Can declare the spouse-name property, relic, person, or void.
Hollow Astronomers	Correspondence	Map Spirit Realm overlaps and forbidden corpse-routes.	Reveal the world is a stacked set of mirrored consequences.
Free Graves	Refusal	People who live outside ledgers, tolls, vows, and official memory.	Ally path for debtless city endings and the rare margin ending.

8. Act Structure

Act	Narrative Function	Key Event Logic
Act 1 - The Name Taken	Small, personal, procedural cruelty. A grave-lantern is taken, a name is chiseled out, and the old craft returns.	The Camp Decides: first major event proves enemies are people, systems, places, and histories, not just health bars.
Act 2 - The City Answers Back	The player learns each revenge action changes routes, witnesses, faction heat, and Shadow behavior.	Court of Equal Knives: the game audits the player and turns prior interactions into prosecution or defense.
Act 3 - The Knife Was an Office	The protagonist discovers they helped build the pruning logic now used against their spouse.	Deep Ledger: endings emerge from accumulated world state rather than a final binary choice.

9. The Shadow Under the New Aesthetic

The Shadow remains the best system in the design, but it should no longer echo zodiac aspects. It mirrors method, not sign. It learns the player through eight observable behaviors: attack direction, distance preference, parry timing, dodge rhythm, ability aspect, mercy avoidance, corpse-route usage, and event-resolution bias.

Visually, the Shadow remains a boiling Rorschach absence with fixed scars. The scars are the only honest geometry. As the player resolves events, the Shadow inherits specific marks: chain burns from Tollroad, ash cracks from Cinder Parish, waterline scars from the Canal, glass fractures from the Lung, nail rings from the Anvil, and root sutures from the Deep Ledger. It is the player as recorded by consequence.

- **Reject:** the Shadow becomes a combat audit. It punishes repetition and forces mastery.
- **Integrate:** the Shadow becomes a witness. It exposes what the player has done and what they refuse to admit.
- **Embrace Void:** the Shadow becomes administrative power. Every target becomes legible, but memory of why it mattered decays.

10. Environmental Storytelling Grammar

No exposition walls. The world explains itself through altered spaces. An event that was solved by violence leaves different props than an event solved by witness, flood, theft, or mercy. This makes replay history visible.

Signal	Meaning
Open ledger with wet pages	A name was altered recently or under duress.
Nails hammered into doorframes	Debt enforcement occurred here; count nails to infer victims.
Black wax on thresholds	Someone tried to keep a Spirit route closed.
Folded cloth without body	A person was administratively removed, not physically buried.
Cracked ceramic bowls with warm ash	Safe rest point, no animal skull shrine required.
Root growth avoiding one object	That object is protected by a vow or remembers a true name.
Bell rope cut at two heights	Living route and Spirit route both affected the room.
Shadow stain with fixed scars	Your past tactics shaped this encounter.

11. Thirteen Endings - No Zodiac Version

The 13 endings are no longer keyed to signs. They are keyed to world-state: how the player resolved events, treated witnesses, used death routes, handled the Shadow, and claimed or refused the spouse-name. The thirteenth ending remains a near-secret route designed for roughly 0.5% of players: not hard because of combat, but rare because it requires restraint, contradiction-hunting, and refusal of normal completion instincts.

#	Ending	Primary Trigger	Final Consequence
1	The Name Returned	Recover all spouse-name fragments and refuse institutional ownership.	The name returns to plain stone. No resurrection. No grand cure. The protagonist remembers without permission.
2	The Cut Ledger	Destroy the Deep Ledger after exposing three factions.	Debts fail across Veyrholt. The city becomes free, starving, violent, and possible.
3	The Root-Bound City	Feed the Ironroot with enough restored names and spare enough witnesses.	The city survives as a living memory organism. It remembers truth, but demands care.
4	The Ash Republic	Resolve most events through sabotage, fire, and public revolt.	The institutions burn. Survivors build law from oral witness and visible scars.
5	The Patient Hammer	Bind Kept Quiet through the Anvil Ward and refuse final vengeance.	The weapon becomes a tool again. The protagonist becomes a maker of exits, not corpses.
6	The Trial of the Knife	Let the Court judge the player with living witnesses still available.	The protagonist is condemned, pardoned, or exiled based on actual play history.
7	The Widow Decree	Let the Widow Courts define the spouse-name as living inheritance.	The spouse remains legally present. Beautiful, unstable, and dangerous to anyone who loves them.
8	The Debtless Road	Break toll systems while keeping Mercy Ledger high.	Roads open. Pilgrims stand upright. A grounded ending for players who free strangers more than they punish enemies.

9	The Glass Witness	Preserve evidence and expose contradictions without burning the archive.	The truth survives, but so do the guilty. A historian's victory, not a killer's.
10	The Salted Root	Stabilize Spirit breaches and deny both Church and Shadow possession.	The rot stops spreading, but frozen grief remains. The city is preserved in a wounded pause.
11	The Hollow Calculation	Use Astronomer routes and entropy choices to resolve without restoring the spouse-name.	The player accepts that some names cannot be recovered without destroying the living.
12	We Are the Darkness Now	Embrace Void after high Shadow Scar Map and high Debt Heat.	The protagonist becomes the corrective event. Every ledger opens. The reason for revenge is forgotten.
13	The Uncounted Margin	Approx. 0.5% path: no faction vow, no formal map reliance, Mercy Ledger above violence ledger, three major events left unresolved, spouse-name carried but not claimed.	A blank door appears where no door was drawn. The protagonist leaves the story-system itself. The city cannot remember or pursue them.

12. Art Prompt Replacement Pass

Use this replacement pass when revising concept prompts. The production look can keep hi-bit dark fantasy, limited palette, black-background character sheets, 16:9 environments, nearest-neighbor scaling, and hand-drawn side-scroller readability. Remove all animal and zodiac anchors.

Old Element	New Ironroot Element
Ram skull helmet / horns	Cracked execution helm, nail crown, iron brow pins, soot-black visor.
Zodiac constellation glow	Vow-suture glow, fracture lines, burn maps, ledger ink under skin.
Zodiac beast / animal ascension	Human silhouette enlarged by ash, cloth, iron, and root pressure. Never animalized.
Corrupted wolf / wildlife enemy	Rooted deserter, fungal oath-effigy, ash-warped debtor, stitched armor husk.
Caged animals	Empty cages, prisoner cages, broken food hooks, abandoned bedding, torn ledger tags.
Animal skull save shrine	Candle cairn, cracked ceramic bowl, blackened nail ring, folded cloth, warm low flame.
Tiny birds / distant wildlife	Ash motes, torn prayer flags, drifting embers, hanging scraps, far-off falling leaves.
Boss arena	Event site with interactable social, environmental, Spirit, and Shadow layers.

13. New One-Sentence Pitch

Ironroot is a grief-driven dark fantasy action RPG where every major confrontation is an event-shaped wound: the city remembers how you fight, who you spare, where you die, which ledgers you break, and whether the Shadow becomes enemy, witness, or throne.

14. Source Alignment Notes

This revision preserves the original direction: tight melee action, metroidvania routing, Jungian Shadow framework, oppressive institutions, physical-cost magic, environmental storytelling, Spirit Realm death traversal, progressive disclosure, and the no-neon/no-sparkle/no-clean-surfaces rule. It removes the previous zodiac and animal layers and replaces them with material, institutional, and event-state systems.

The new art posture is aligned with the uploaded concept-generation handoff: dark fantasy, side-scroller, handcrafted sprite aesthetic, limited-palette feel, black-background character references, atmospheric environments, and negative prompt constraints against neon, pristine, sparkle, gradient, anti-aliased, watermark, text overlay, aurora, and northern lights.